INDIVIDUAL HIGHLIGHT

Your full name: Julián Perez Krohn

Your team: Team Hate Fish

Your Role within your team: Level Designer

The name of your Boss Prototype: The Kraken

Miro board:
https://miro.com/app/board/uXjVGy_LbHE=/?share_link_id=182028882207

Canva: https://canva.link/k5eisas0gd05s8u

Gameplay video: https://youtu.be/b9l_qhYmrbY?si=fPHYO0DxJODrYHzw

Devlog:

First day (03/08) - Start of assignment.

We assembled a team of designers that shared the same space to have an easier time communicating and collaborating, as well as having different strengths. We chose Nikoloz Ninua as the leader and then started brainstorming the general concept of the game. During that time, we jumped into Epic's FAB store to look for free assets that shared a common purpose and aesthetic, and that's how we found a Kraken and an Atlantis ruins pack. We had a boss and a place, and soon after FPS would be the genre that would tie everything together.

I also setted up the Miro board, the Diversion workspace and the Unreal project with version 5.4, as we wanted to make an underwater game. We knew that normal pathing wouldn't work in a 3D space, so we found a plugin that allowed us exactly that.

First week

I decided to work on the level design, so I used the Miro board to start sketching out the general layout of the level. I took measurements based on the desired boss size and Unreal Engine character to build the space, we knew we wanted a short tutorial section with a few enemies and then a big arena. And as soon as I had the general design done, and being green lit by the lead, I started recreating the map in the engine. Soon I had a first draft of the general level and then continued with improving the design by adding details, a few assets and testing AI movement that Nikoloz made.

During this time I also added many assets from FAB to test them out and see their viability for their project, such as caves, sea creatures, weapons, material packs, water effects.

Second week

During this time two major changes were made:

First, we had to rework the player movement as we were using the default player character from Unreal, which was enough to be playable, but not good for the type of game we were creating for. So we had to dedicate a full day of work to stop development and sort that problem out. After talking with our mentor we proposed different ideas, and we ended up choosing mine: a player can hold down any movement key to swim around at a slow but constant pace, or if a player waited between inputs they would have a boost in speed to replicate swim strokes. Also tweaked values of player friction, gravity, inertia and other values to mimic that underwater feeling.

Second, our boss designer was having trouble implementing all the features we discussed. So we ended up limiting the boss to be static.

These changes would change the level based on the new specifications, specially reducing arena size to allow the combat mechanics to feel meaningful.

By the end of the week, these changes were done, as well as the introduction of materials, lighting, environmental assets, general polishing and destruction of the environment, the boss trigger and its presentation. Besides the player control I added a few settings to have a transition between land and water.

Third week

By this point the level was mostly done, so I was able to help in other areas and tied the experience down: introduced the AI into the level, worked in fixing boss attacks, boss states in relation to the combat arena and patterns, weapon projectiles and its related interactions, added spawners, some vfx, and general polishing.

Collaboration:

Besides the many brainstorming sessions we had to think about the game we were creating, I also worked as the producer, so I tried having daily meetings with the team, or at least messaging the current state of the game. I kept track of the different features we were working on and their merging on the level. We had constant daily discussions of features, game feeling and feedback systems to improve the experience.

Besides being blocked from having to spend a day to fix the player movement, I cannot remember any other instance that stopped me from working. I was always able to find something to work on, or at least discuss with a member about their work and give a hand based on their need.

Feature:

One of them was coming up with the player movement system, it was a merge of a dash system that we scrapped later on but reused to have the swim stroke/underwater impulse. It helped the team member get a notion on player speed around the level so in turn would modify the Boss attacks and Minions. It also required feedback systems to provide the players visual and sound elements to engage with the mechanic, which was done by our UI, VFX and Sound Designers.

Then, the level itself and the assets built to showcase them. It was a collaboration with the members that worked with: Boss, Minion, VFX and Sound. The level tied everything up for them to show off their work.

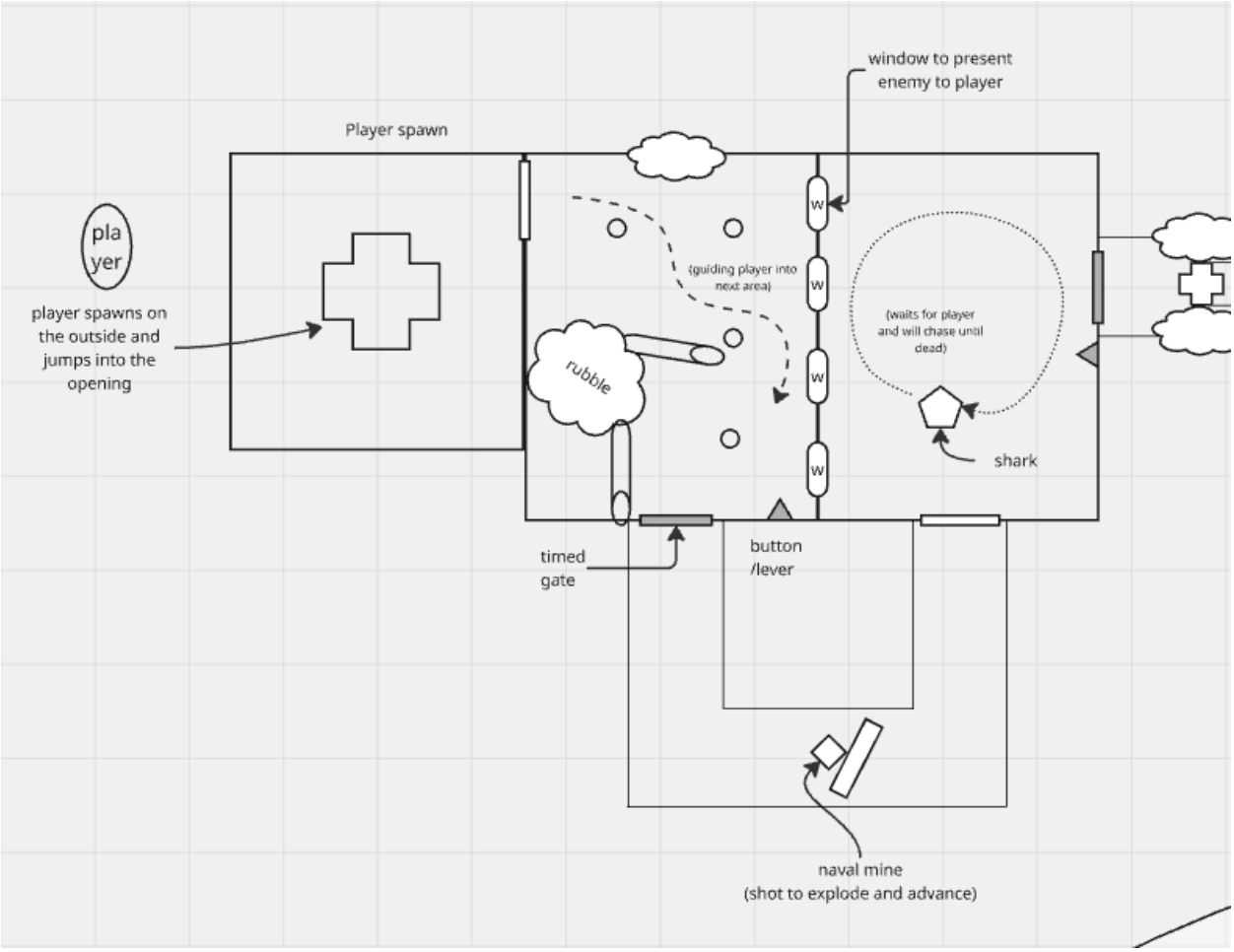
Your best work:

Level design

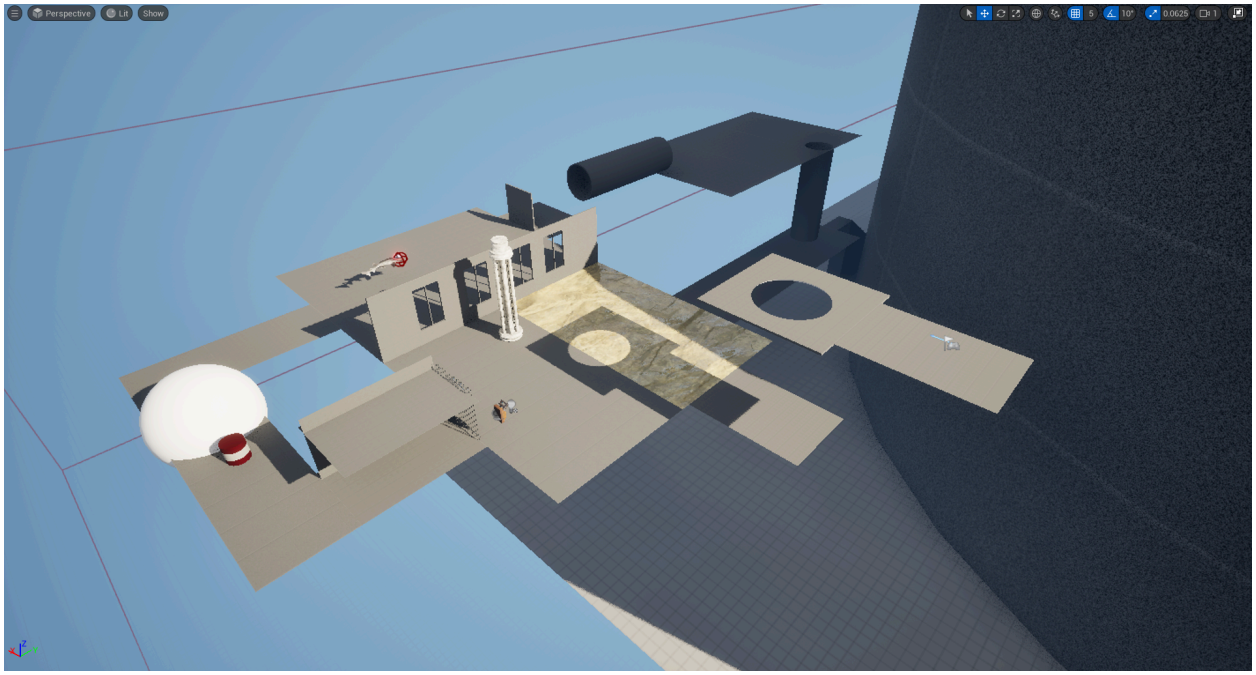
- Initial section

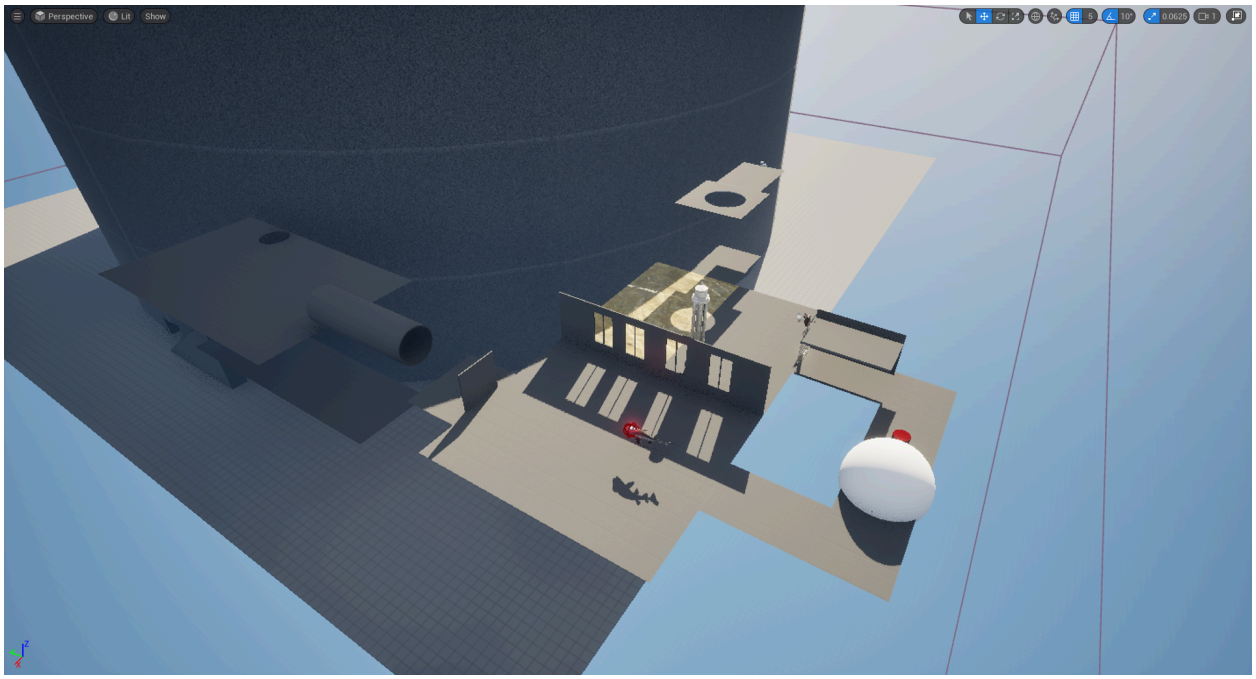
Miro sketch

Town down view of the introduction of the game: player spawns in a safe place, they have to jump into the water and learn how to move underwater, the windows are used to present a threat which the player will face but to get there, they need to learn about using levers, gates, explosive barrels and destructible environment.

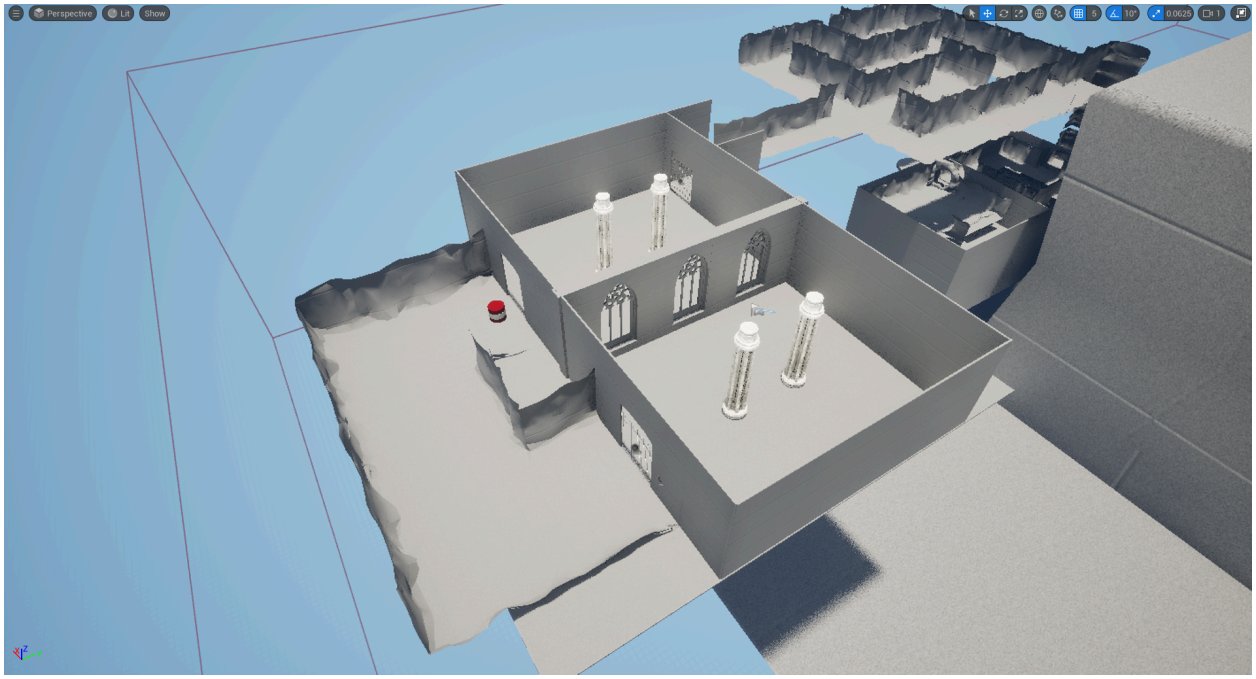


Initial greybox





Polished greybox



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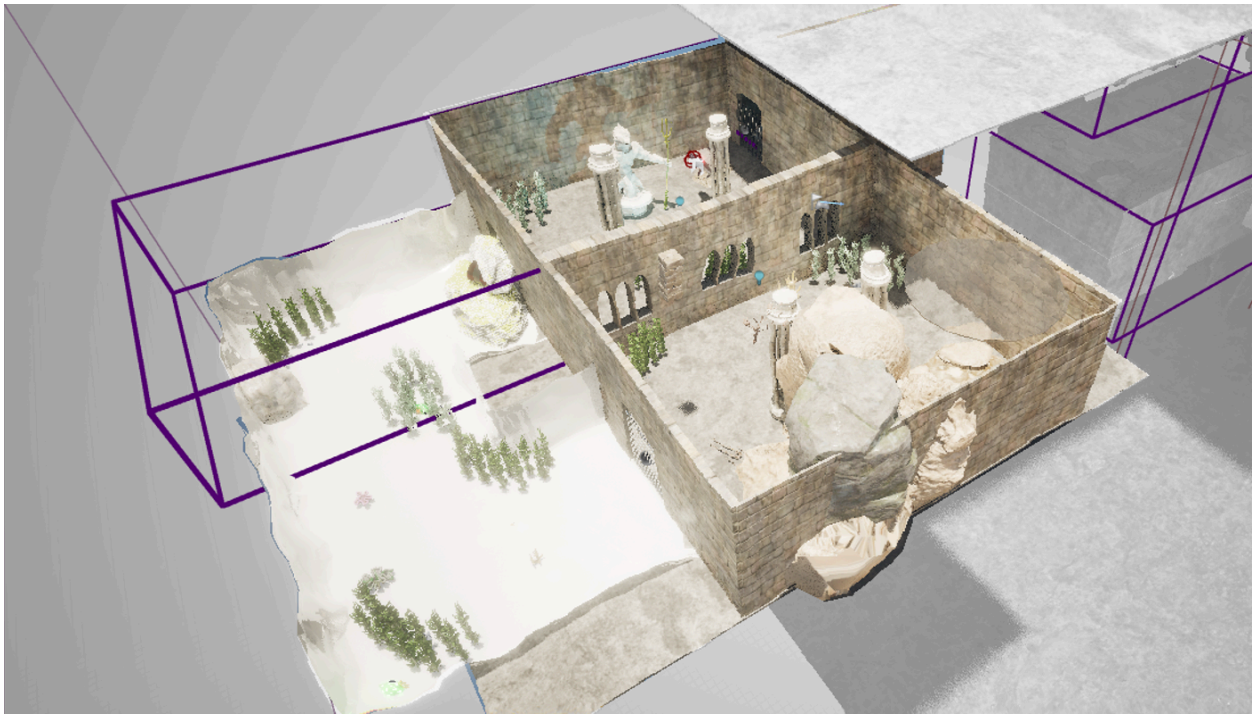
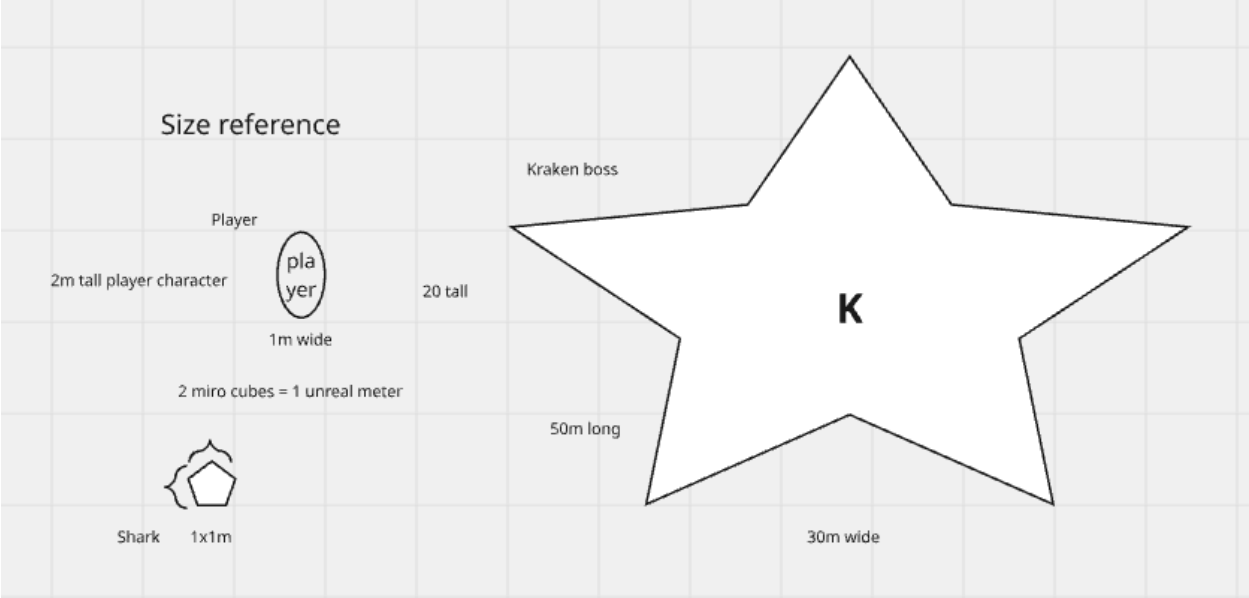


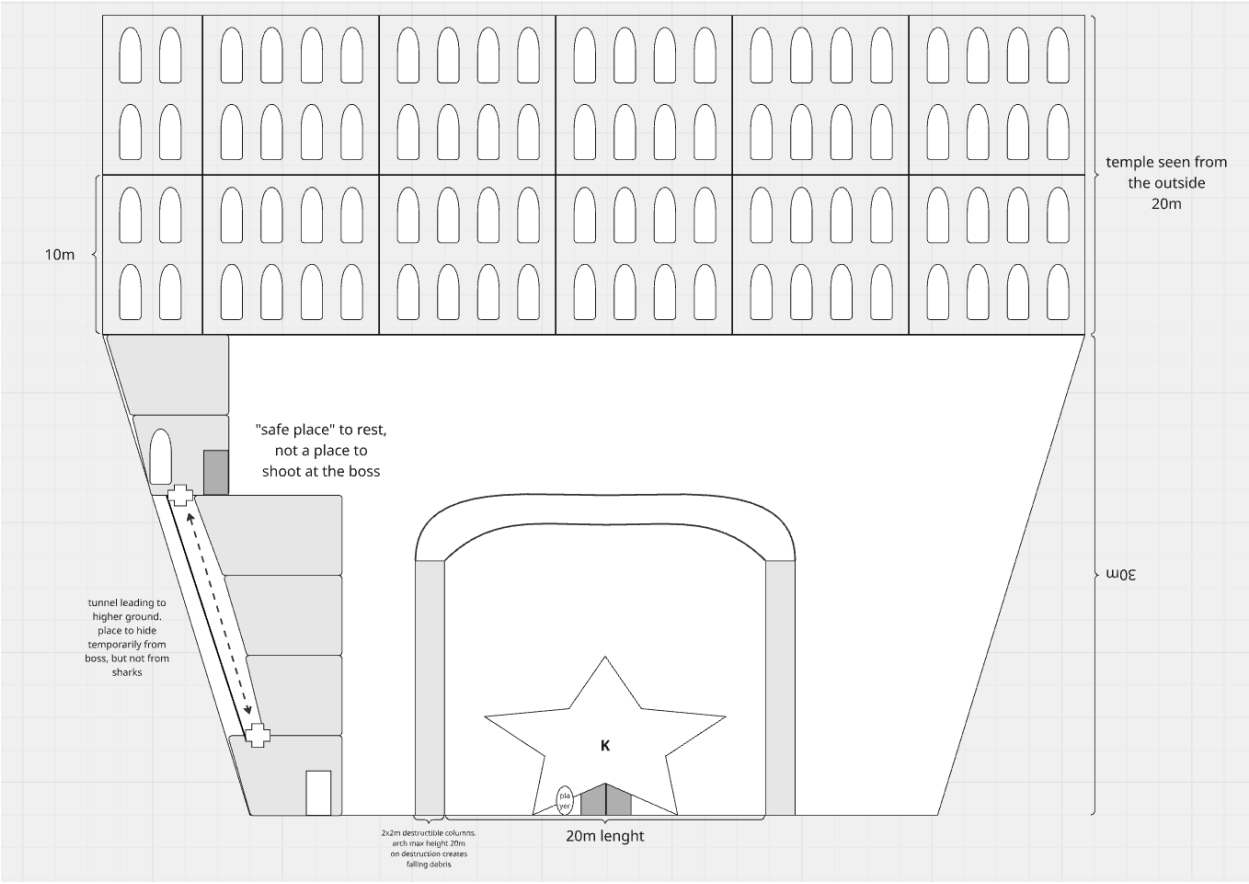
- Boss Arena

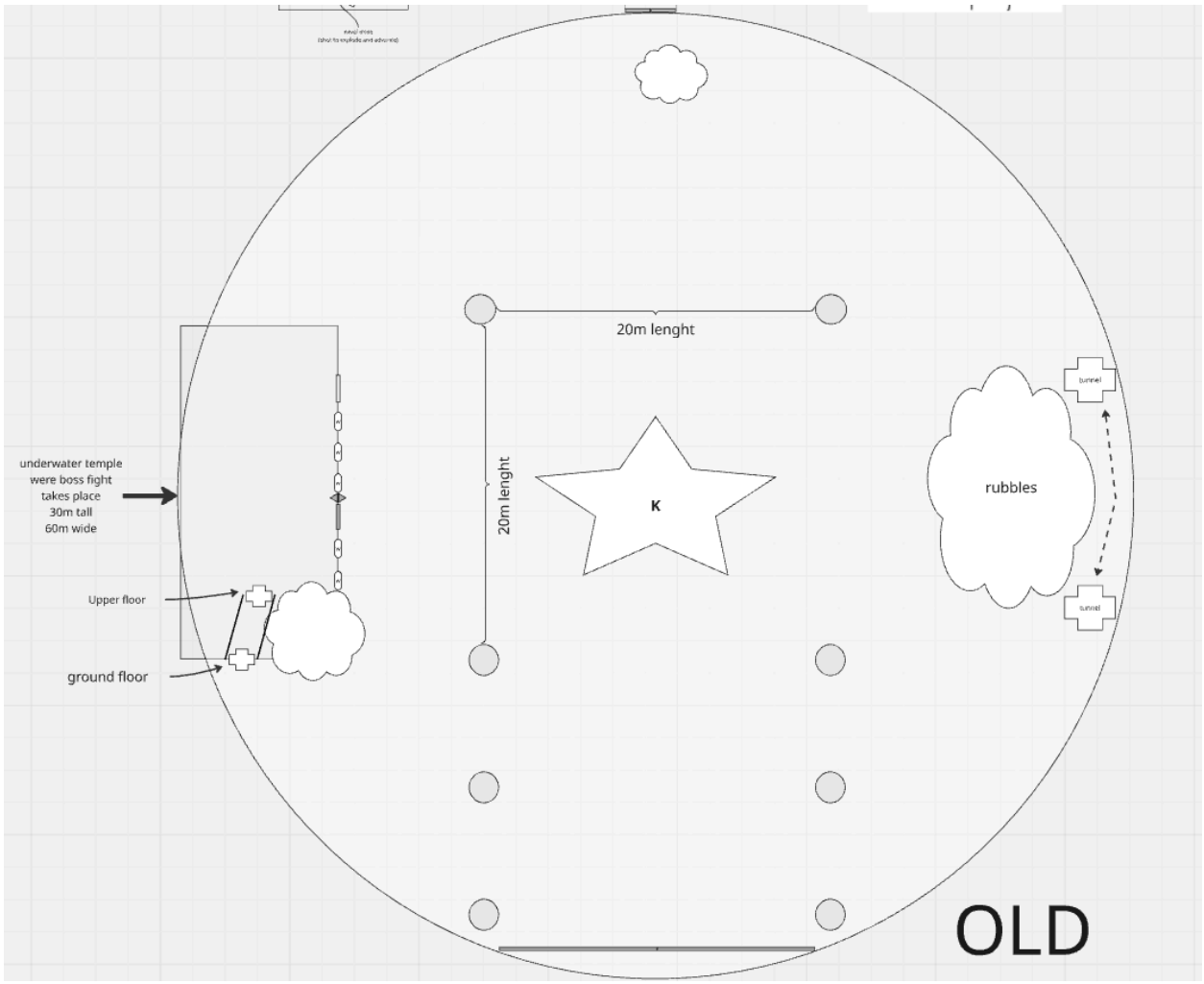
Miro sketch

These were the references I used to design the level, to create narrow corridors for players and sharks to swim around, and the Boss size to shape the arena.

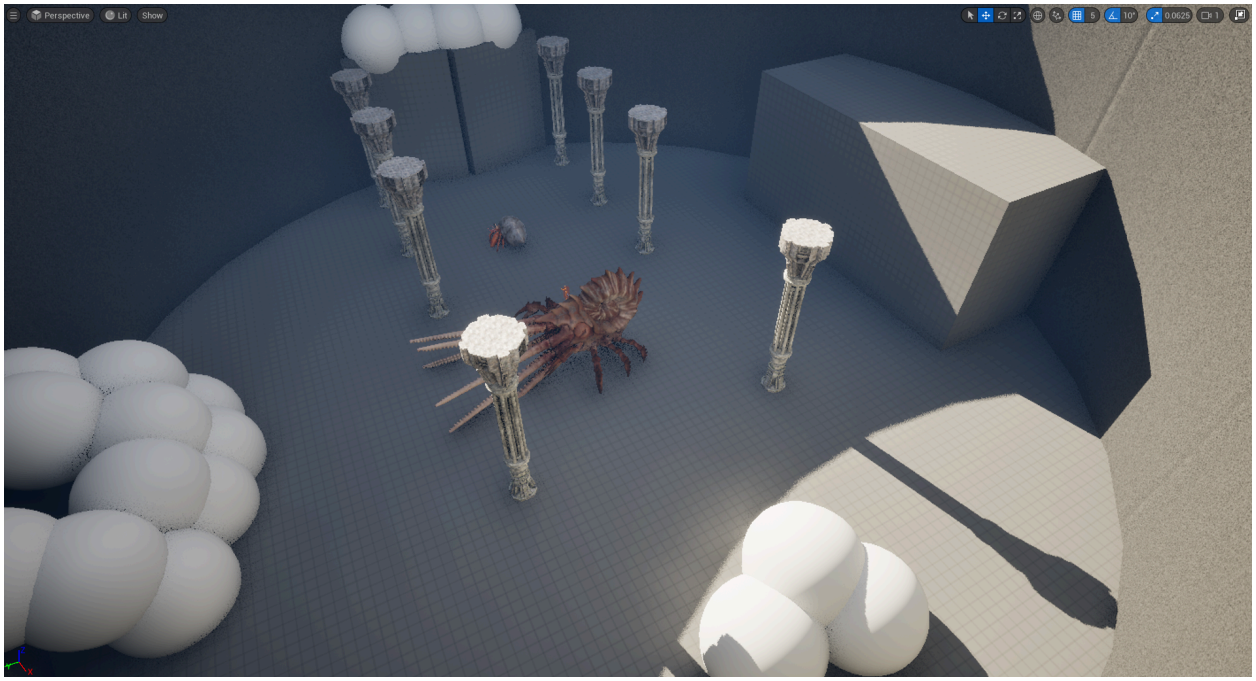


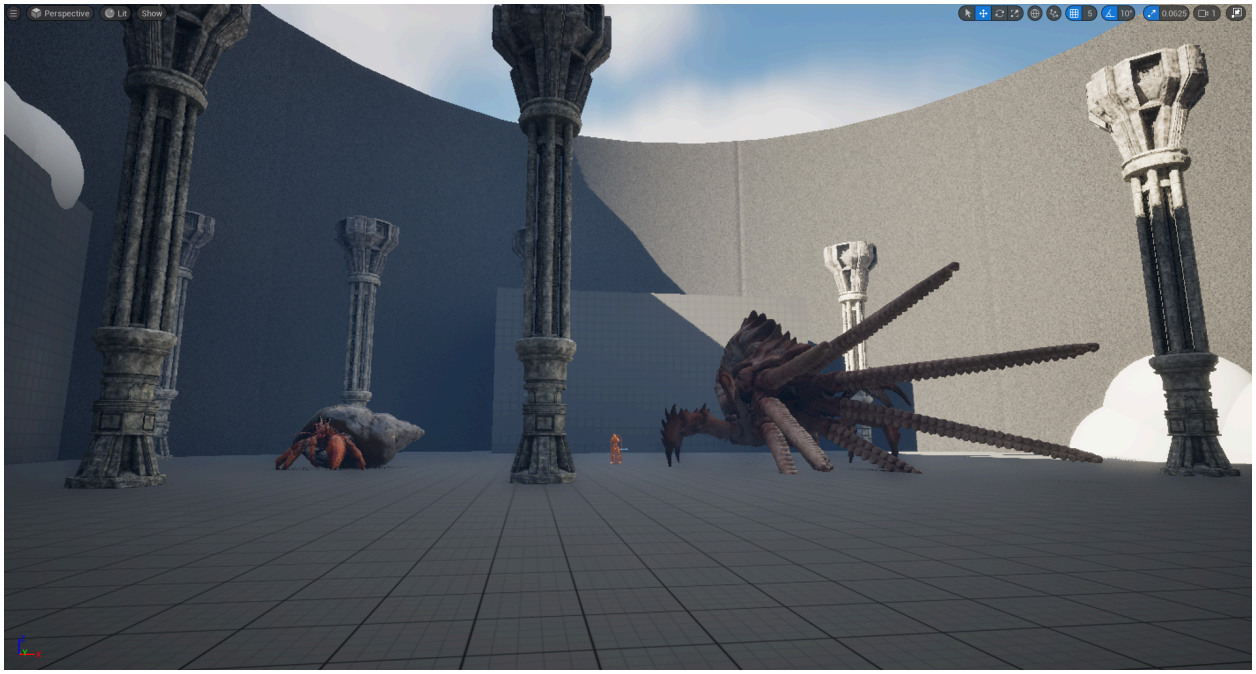
I wanted to showcase the arena where the combat would take place and it had to be big enough as to reflect the danger of the challenge. The space intended for the original was quite big, so the boss could move to different locations and hunt down the player, while also allowing the player to hide but not shoot back at the boss.




20m lenght
20m lenght
K
underwater temple
were boss fight
takes place
30m tall
60m wide
Upper floor
ground floor
rubbles
tunnel
tunnel
OLD

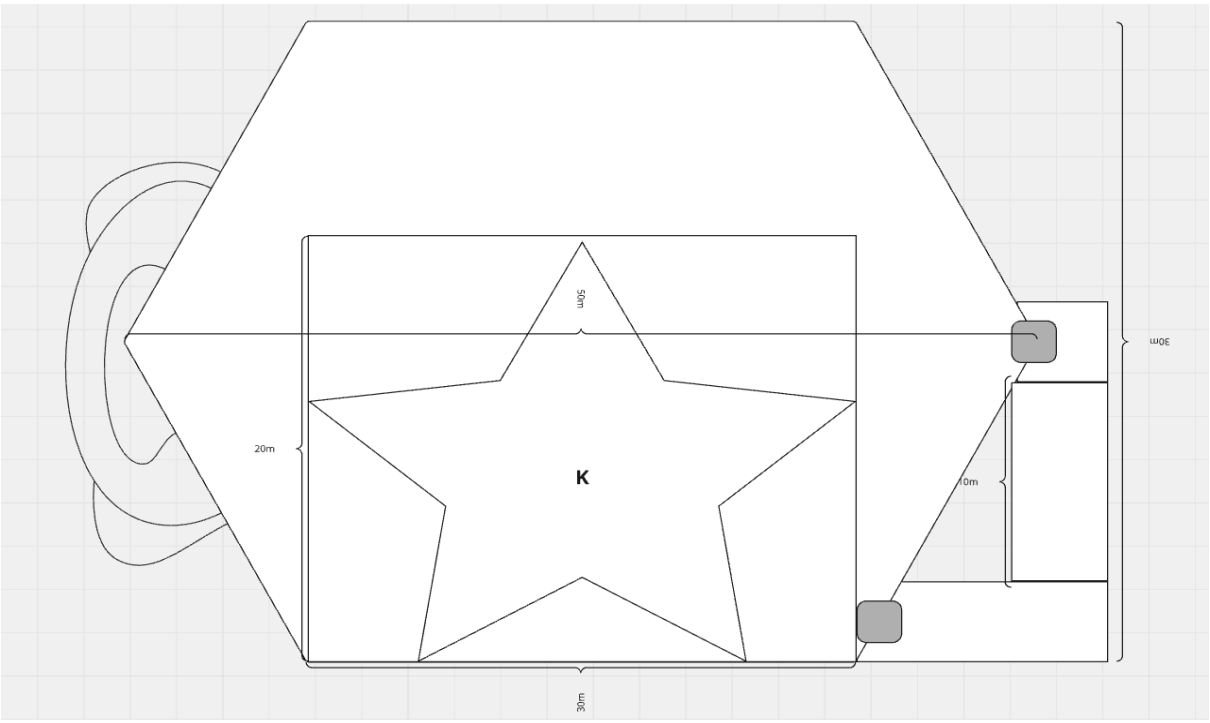
Initial greybox

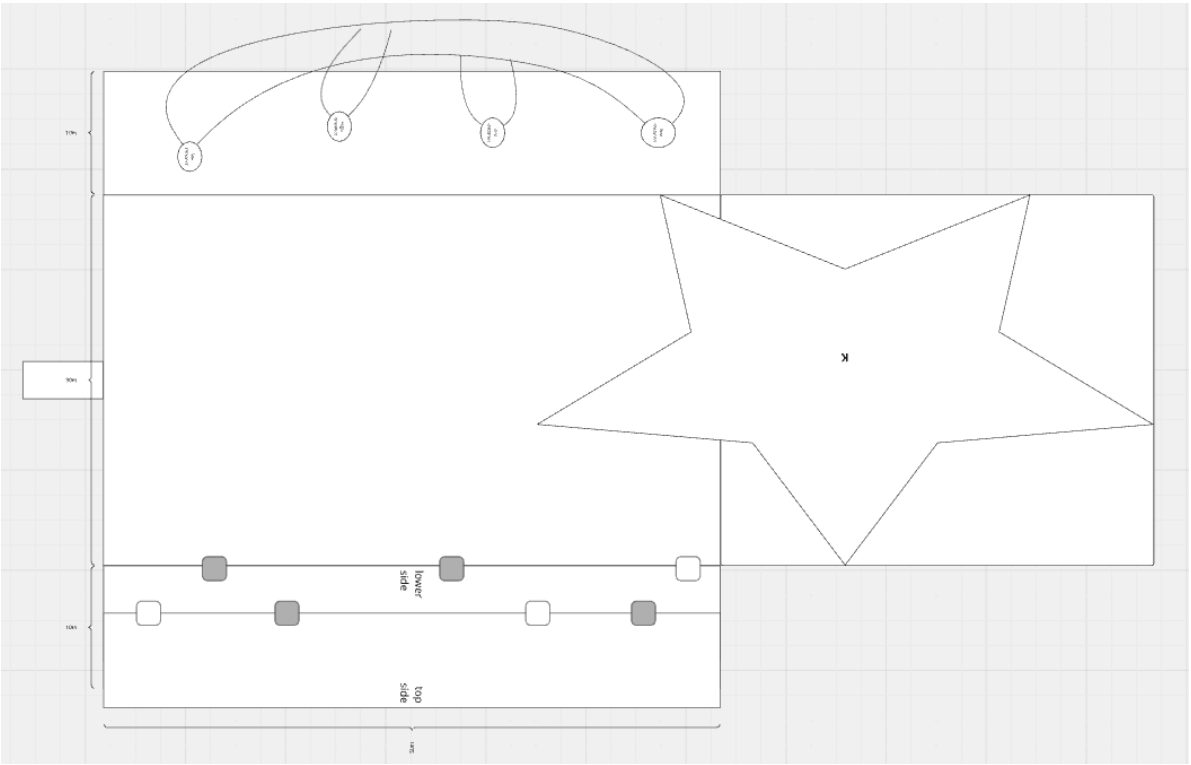




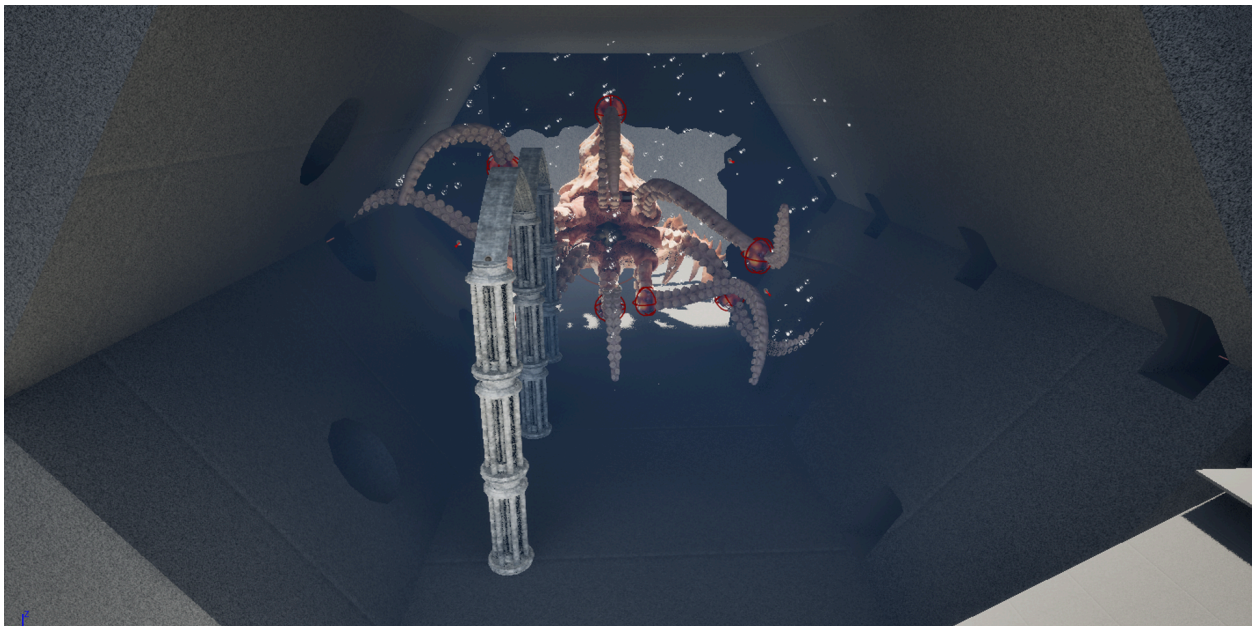
Miro sketch after boss update

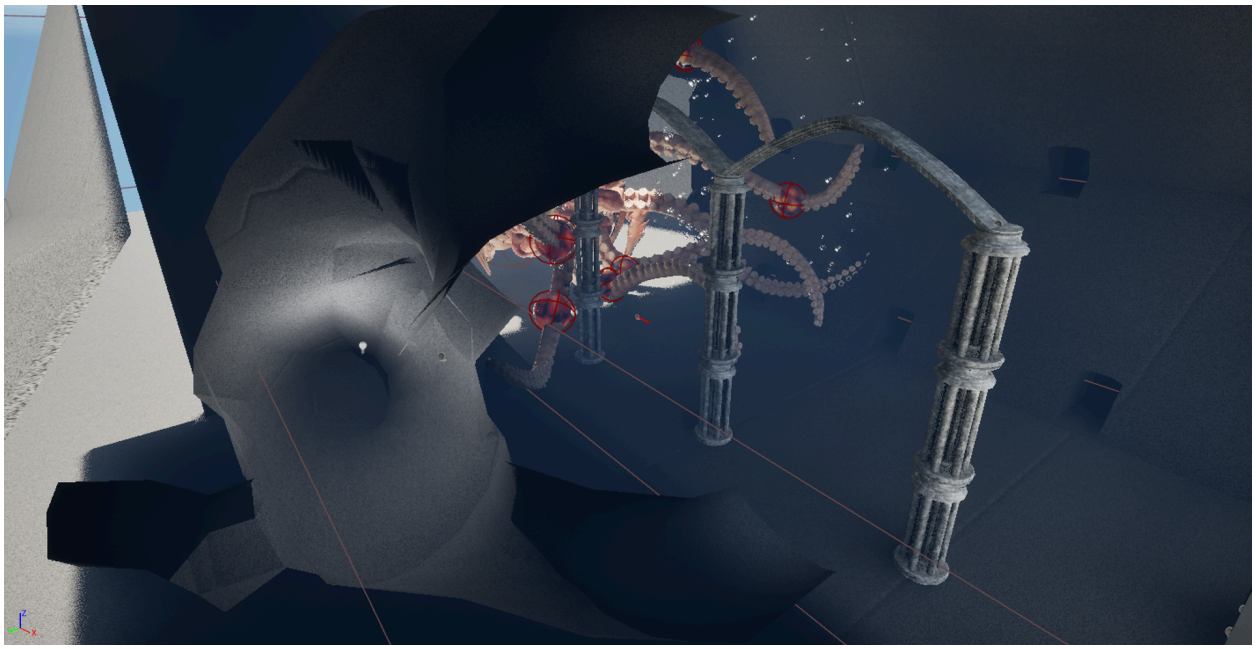
As I mentioned before, we limited the boss to a static position so the arena was reduced in size, but we kept the features mentioned before. A player must fight the kraken head on, but also have room to breath. In this version, the player can fight from a relatively safe place, which requires the boss to have an additional attack that could reach the player.

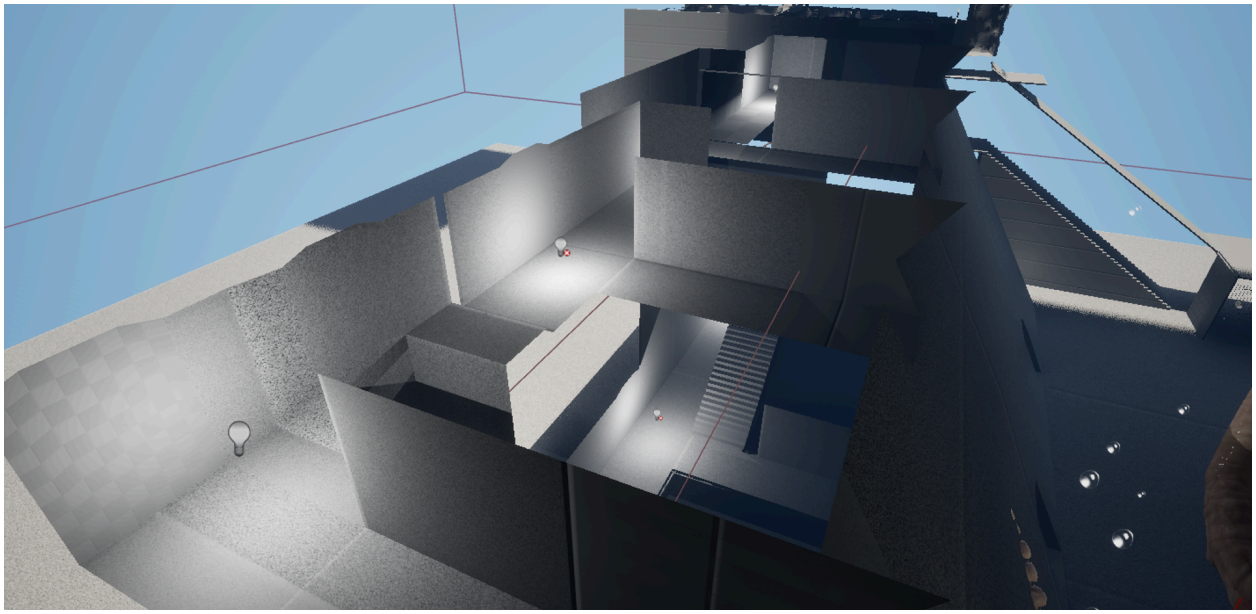




Greybox update







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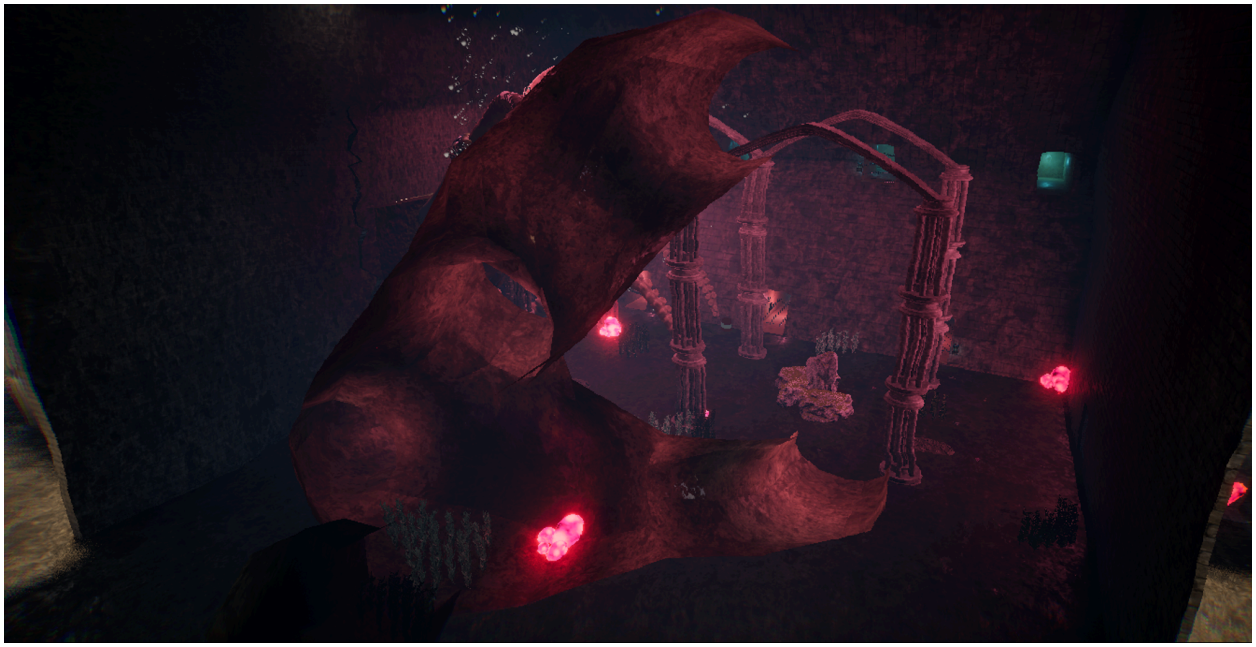

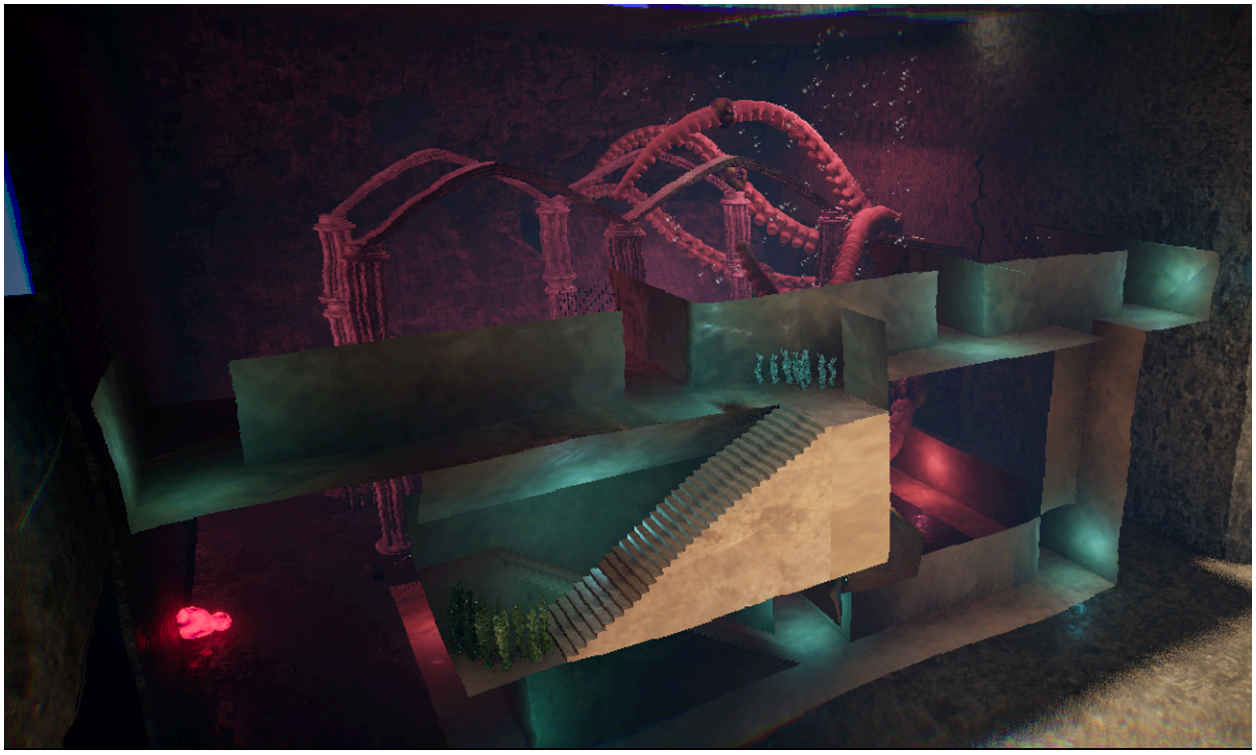

The level itself presents a good sense of exploration, mystery and danger, which is good for the type of game we created. I think the level in general is good enough for a demo, but requires polishing to improve level readability, and then it will require testing with more players to see how they explore the environment. There's a problem between the boss arena and the frequency of the attack patterns, which makes the fight quite chaotic and sometimes hard to follow. It either requires an increase in size to reduce pressure on the player, or delay the attacks and make them more telegraphed.

What did you learn:

Creating an underwater fantasy is hard as there are many elements we don't consider and become a problem when trying to create a fun experience. I believe the solution we implemented for underwater movement is good, it could be better and more rewarding. It fits well with the boss design as it allows the player to be in constant motions and avoid the attacks, but then again it can be easy to some extent (since I'm experienced with it). The weapons are a problem. We didn't have enough time to polish so they don't feel satisfying nor interesting for the type of environment the player experiences.

This is my first attempt as a level designer in FG, and I believe I did well with my step by step process and design for the player to enjoy. Player movement comes before the level, so next time that will be considered a priority and prevent blocking the team midway through the process.

Playtest

I organized a playtest session for our game and it was pretty casual, I let them play normally, I tried not commenting on it as the game should speak for itself and then took notes based on the problems I saw, as well as their comments on what is missing, doesn't fit or feels unbalanced.

Salivic: Tree Massacre:

- Attack patterns and telegraphed attacks are the most important elements of the combat. Making the game readable makes the experience fun and fair.
- Combat arenas should be either, contained spaces for slow moving/static bosses, or big arenas with mobile bosses.
- Boss phases must be noticeable and have an impact on the game. Increase the stakes.

Further Development:

More fish, bigger fish, more guns, bigger guns, more hate, saving more dogs. Destroy the hivemind menace!